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Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 11, 2025 • \$4

Syrian president meets Trump

Former militant Sharaa seeks to deepen U.S. ties with White House visit

BY KAREEM FAHIM, CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR. AND SUSANNAH GEORGE

Syrian President Ahmed al-Sharaa met with President Donald Trump at the White House on Monday, the latest in a series of once-unthinkable moments for his country and another unlikely stop in the former militant's personal journey.

Once imprisoned by U.S. forces in Iraq, Sharaa went on to lead Syria's al-Qaeda affiliate and now, as interim head of state, appears in smiling photos with presidents and prime ministers around the world while seeking their help as Syria emerges from decades of dictatorship and war.

On Monday, after a historic first trip to the White House by a Syrian leader, Sharaa stepped out of his motorcade and greeted a cheering throng of supporters gathered just outside, many waving Syrian flags.

Since Sharaa, 43, led rebel forces that toppled Syrian dictator Bashar al-Assad in December, Trump has become one of the new leader's more enthusiastic global backers, a bond rooted in U.S. perceptions of the country's strategic importance but also Trump's apparent personal regard.

"Tough guy," Trump said of Sharaa after the two men first met in May. "Very strong past. Fighter." SEE SYRIA ON A13

Kennedy's allies revel in newly found clout

Anti-vaccine group exults in successes, plans for future at its convention

BY LAUREN WEBER

AUSTIN — A top Robert F. Kennedy Jr. ally rallied anti-vaccine activists over the weekend with an exhortation to stay strong in the face of attacks by the government, media and mainstream medical figures.

"God is an anti-vaxxer, and he needs you to speak up," said Del Bigtree, a former top Kennedy political adviser and head of the anti-vaccine group Informed Consent Action Network. He urged the health secretary's supporters to press their fight at a weekend-long celebration of their newfound Washington influence.

After spending years on the fringes of the medical community and dismissed as peddlers of dangerous misinformation about vaccine safety, the anti-vaccine group Kennedy founded, Children's Health Defense, is now stronger than ever and wielding clout in President Donald Trump's administration.

With about 1,000 people in attendance, members of the group reveled in its success at its annual convention in Austin on

SEE VACCINES ON A15



MAXINE WALLACE/THE WASHINGTON POST

Russell Sattazahn, 99, lost his right hand a couple of months after the Battle of the Bulge.

For the last WWII vets, day is not yet done

80 years after the Allied victory, reflections on duty, loss and time

BY JOE HEIM

World War II was nearing its end in March 1945 when Russell Sattazahn found himself taking cover from enemy fire with other GIs in the basement of a German house. At first they felt protected, but the onslaught was unrelenting. An artillery shell ripped through the brick, mortar and wood. Sattazahn, who had fought with the Army's 1st Infantry Division a couple of months earlier in the bloody Battle of the Bulge, looked down and saw that his right hand had been blown off. His first thought, he remembers, was, "I'm never going to play baseball again."

He was 18. Now 99, Sattazahn told that story at the American Veterans Center's annual conference this past weekend at the Omni Shoreham Hotel in Washington. There he joined veterans of America's wars, including 40 World War II veterans, to share their experiences, remember the battles they fought and think again of the friendships that survived — and the ones war ended in an instant.

Some had told their stories before, but others were sharing them publicly for the first time.

Sattazahn, who lives in Schaefferstown,

Pennsylvania, said people didn't want to hear stories about the war when he first got back to the States. He also worried that people might think he was bragging about his experience. So he stayed quiet. At the conference he thanked the audience, which included veterans of other wars, ROTC students and members of the service academies. But he asked them not to call him a hero.

"I was over there. I saw the heroes," he said, choking back tears. "I came home."

For the American World War II veterans, all in their late 90s or early 100s, the event marked what will be one of the last times they gather to publicly relay what they endured and how it shaped them. And, perhaps, to offer lessons that a polarized America today might absorb from their sacrifice to fight and defeat fascism.

The veterans will be honored as part of the program "American Valor: A Salute To Our Heroes," which will be broadcast on various channels beginning on Veterans Day. About 16.4 million Americans served in the Armed Forces in World War II. In 2025, there are approximately 45,000 who are still alive according to the National WWII Museum. Here are some of their stories.

SEE VETERANS ON A9

Senate passes bill to reopen government

'THE END IS IN SIGHT' FOR SHUTDOWN

House set to take up measure later in the week

BY RILEY BEGGIN AND THEODORIC MEYER

The Senate passed a bill to reopen the federal government Monday evening, taking the next step toward ending the longest shutdown in U.S. history.

The chamber had already agreed to speed up the process to pass a bipartisan agreement struck over the weekend. The measure will now head to the House, which is expected to take it up later this week after staying away from Washington for more than 50 days.

"I could spend an hour talking about all the problems we've seen, which have snowballed the longer this shutdown has gone on," Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-South Dakota) said in a floor speech Monday. "But all of us, Democrat and Republican, who voted for last night's bill are well aware of the facts, and I am grateful that the end is in sight."

The bill passed 60-40, with seven Democrats and Sen. Angus King (I-Maine) joining Republicans to pass it. One Republican, Sen. Rand Paul (Kentucky), voted no.

The bipartisan compromise combines three full-year funding measures for specific parts of the government into one package, along with a stopgap funding bill

for the rest of it through Jan. 30. President Donald Trump is expected to sign the bill into law.

The bill would also reverse more than 4,000 federal layoffs the Trump administration attempted to implement earlier in the shutdown and prevent future layoffs through Jan. 30, easing pressure on a federal workforce reeling from tens of thousands of layoffs this year. The deal would appropriate funding for the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, also known as SNAP or food stamps, through September.

But it would not extend Affordable Care Act subsidies set to expire at the end of the year, increasing health care costs for millions of Americans. Democrats had demanded throughout the shutdown that Republicans negotiate with them to extend the subsidies, but the GOP insisted it would not discuss health policy unless the government reopened.

The shutdown has now lasted 41 days, and most federal employees haven't been paid since it began. Effects are piling up: Hundreds of thousands are working without salaries, and many others are furloughed. Airline delays have cascaded because of air traf-

SEE SHUTDOWN ON A8

Flights: Cancellations continue as more travel reductions loom. **A4**

President again appeals to justices in SNAP fight

BY MARK BERMAN AND JUSTIN JOUVENAL

The Trump administration on Monday again asked the Supreme Court to block lower-court decisions requiring it to pay full food assistance benefits to about 42 million Americans who rely on the nation's largest anti-hunger program.

The request marked the second time in a few days that Trump officials have urged the justices to intervene in a court battle over Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) payments and prevent other judges from forcing the administration to fully fund benefits for November.

In his filing to the high court, Solicitor General D. John Sauer castigated judges who have ruled against the administration on the issue. Decisions about what programs to fund are "precisely the prerogative of the political

branches, not of the politically unaccountable federal courts," Sauer wrote.

The SNAP program ran out of funds on Nov. 1 because of the government shutdown. SNAP payments, formerly known as food stamps, are essential for millions of people, many of whom depend upon them to afford groceries. Most of the people relying on SNAP are children, the elderly or disabled adults.

The Trump administration has resisted tapping money from other government resources that could pay for the food relief,

SEE SNAP ON A8

Same-sex marriage: Challenge to the 2015 ruling is turned down. **A2**

ICE contractor: A detention firm seeks immunity from a lawsuit. **A2**

Mail-in voting: Justices take case on when ballots can arrive. **A2**



CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

William Goode, 85, a former engineer and avid painter, took a dementia screening test offered by Iona, a local nonprofit.

A social rethinking of dementia care

Advocates push for an approach that emphasizes community, interaction

BY MICHAEL BRICE-SADDLER

The social worker's instructions came one after another: *Count backward from 100 by sevens. Name as many words as you can that start with the letter "F" in one minute. Memorize five terms.*

William Goode, 85, smoothed the wrinkles from his neon-green tracksuit and prepared to tackle each task with the swagger of a man who has never doubted his memory. A former engineer and avid painter, he keeps his mind

busy with projects. He is mastering pyrography, the art of burning intricate designs into wood, and every evening, without fail, he settles in for his favorite mental workout: "Jeopardy!"

Now, on a sun-soaked bench outside his D.C. senior apartment complex, it was time for Goode to put his sharpness to the test. Seated beside him, the social worker explained that the Montreal Cognitive Assessment, or MoCA, was designed to help flag signs of memory loss. He told Goode the test could reveal nor-

mal cognitive function or the possibility of mild to severe impairment.

He also told Goode he would get his results within minutes.

The dementia diagnoses of public figures like Bruce Willis, Wendy Williams and Tony Bennett in recent years have helped turn private battles into national conversations about memory and aging. Even so, specialists say the country is dangerously underprepared for what's ahead, a crisis that will only intensify as

SEE DEMENTIA ON A6

IN THE NEWS

Pardons issued President Donald Trump extended clemency to dozens of people who sought to overturn the 2020 election. **A3**

Hormone replacement therapy The Food and Drug Administration will no longer require warnings on medications aimed at treating the symptoms of menopause. **A5**

THE NATION **Trump threatened** to sue the British Broadcasting Corp. over an editing scandal. **A3** **U.S. forces** struck two more vessels allegedly smuggling drugs, killing six people. **A3**

THE WORLD **A prominent far-right** German activist has applied for political asylum in the United States. **A10** **Canada has lost** its measles-free status, a public health organization announced. **A12**

THE ECONOMY **The president's** fire-brand housing finance director fired internal watchdogs at Fannie Mae who were looking into an ally. **A14** **Trump has floated** giving out rebates from tariff funds, but doing so would be difficult and ultimately unlikely. **A14**

STYLE **Rose Byrne**, who made her name in comedies such as "Bridesmaids," channels the rage of Gen X moms in her latest role. **B1**

SPORTS **The Nationals** hired the Tampa Bay Rays' Michael Johns to be their bench coach. **B7**

THE REGION **For a Maryland** woman furloughed by the federal government, hitting job fairs is part of a new routine. **B13** **In Prince George's** County, officials announced a breakthrough spurred by genetic genealogy in the case of a 1998 killing. **B13**

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